

There is no in-ear detection here. I give it a pass, considering the price.

AUDIO PERFORMANCE

The OnePlus Nord Buds 3r uses a 12.4 mm dynamic driver system tuned primarily for deep bass. This driver size is also found in the Nord Buds 3 (Rs 1,899), Noise Buds Xero (Rs 1,999), Nord Buds 3 Pro (Rs 2,599), the Realme Buds T310 (Rs 2,198), and CMF by Nothing Buds 2a (Rs 2,199). OnePlus combines the driver with a titanium-coated diaphragm for clarity in treble. The result, as per our testing, is a V-shaped frequency response. In simpler words, the bass and treble are boosted while the midrange is recessed. So, you can expect a sound signature that's energetic and appealing for most mainstream music, though not always accurate.

The bass feels weighty and thumpy. On tracks like *'Pull Me Under'* by Dream Theater and *'Selkies'* by Between the Buried and Me, and *'Around the World'* by Kings of Leon, the kick drums and bass guitars hit strongly. However, the boosted bass tends to mask some detail and clarity, especially in dense mixes. In the aforementioned songs, the fine textures of guitars lose sparkle. In the case of *'Hurt'* by Johnny Cash, the singer's gravelly voice and its fragile quiver can be heard. Still, overall, I feel there is a need for more space/room. The sound staging is narrow, and it is noticeable especially in tracks like *'Hotel California'* by Eagles.

This was in no means a detriment to my listening experience. For instance, in *'Centuries'* by Fall Out Boy, I liked the voice, and the guitar didn't feel harsh to my ears. Since the treble is smooth but rolled off, this could help in allaying fatigue for some. Moreover, for a budget earphone, this tuning makes sense, as the masses prefer bass.

By the way, the supported codecs are AAC and SBC. I heard songs in the more efficient AAC codec. OnePlus 3D Audio didn't do much spatial wonders for us. So, I turned it off.

The buds also get plenty loud. The 80% volume is louder than my personal

Galaxy Buds 2. Due to this loudness, you may not miss the absence of ANC much. But at 50-60% volume, you will hear just enough ambient sound to stay aware of your surroundings.

One more thing, the passive isolation offered by the earbuds' seal was good enough to weaken the noise of the air purifier in my room.

Let's now see how calls sound on this pair of earbuds.

CALL AND CONNECTIVITY

For calls, the OnePlus Buds 3r perform reliably indoors. I could hear the other person's voice very clearly, and they could hear mine too.

There's also AI call noise cancellation that filters environmental sounds during voice calls. But the recipient said they could hear people around me.

Dual-device connectivity is a welcome inclusion. You can stay connected to two devices simultaneously, switching automatically when audio starts playing on either of the devices. Bluetooth stability remains solid, too. It supports Bluetooth 5.4.

Let's now see how long it can run.

BATTERY AND CHARGING

OnePlus quotes 12 hours of playback at 50% volume with AAC codec from the 58mAh battery. Based on testing, the buds lose about 10% in 1 hour and 48 minutes at 80% volume. Even if you keep volume, codec and other aspects constant, this should last a working day. It lasted 12 hours in our continuous music playback test. Coupled with the 560mAh case, we were able to get a total runtime close to 50 hours.

And when the Buds 3r seek juice, plug in a USB-C charger to get a quick top-up. The company claims a 10-minute charge for 8 hours of playback. That should be reassuring when you are in a pinch.

FINALLY, IT IS TIME FOR THE END NOTE:

Should you consider buying the OnePlus Nord Buds 3r?

The OnePlus Nord Buds 3r is built for users who prioritise strong bass and long battery life from a TWS earphone priced under Rs 2,000. It gets several things right for the segment.

The sound is lively and bass-driven, which makes most songs, especially from genres like EDM, pop, and hip-hop, more enjoyable. However, mids are slightly recessed, highs are softened, and the soundstage feels narrow. That said, you may enjoy this tuning, and the loud output ensures immersion even without ANC. Call quality is decent indoors, and while AI call noise cancellation doesn't fully remove background chatter, it performs acceptably for short calls. The dual-device connection and Google Fast Pair support add to usability, and the IP55 rating is a welcome bonus at this price. Battery life and fast charging are reassuring, too.

A main omission is Active Noise Cancellation. Buds 3R's alternatives like the Boat Nirvana Ion, Realme Buds T310, CMF Buds 2a, and Noise Buds Xero offer ANC. Even the slightly more expensive Nord Buds 3 offer this feature.

But if you are on a strict budget, and you want a well-built, bass-rich, and long-lasting earphone from a trusted brand, you can consider the OnePlus Nord Buds 3r for Rs 1,799. It's not the most detailed or open-sounding option, but it's certainly one of the most enjoyable at this price. Check it out on OnePlus' official website and other online platforms like Amazon and Flipkart.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Drivers: 12.4 mm dynamic | Frequency Response: 20 - 20k Hz | Microphone: 2 mics per side | Weight(earbuds): 4.5 g | Weight (Case): 38.6 g | Battery (Earbuds): 58 mAh | Battery (Case): 560 mAh | Charging: Type C

CONTACT

Company: OnePlus India | Phone: 18001028411 | Email: Web Form | Website: <https://service.oneplus.com/in>

Read more on Digit.in:
tinyurl.com/7t8tgu